Am I My Brother's “Keeper”?

Neal A. Maxwell,
Wherefore, Ye Must Press Forward, pg. 87-88.

Perhaps a reason for not pressing forward in developing our capacity to love is that we have come to think of being responsible for our brothers and sisters in the wrong way.

Cain asked, “Am I my brother's keeper?” (Gen 4:9.) Presumably he responded to the Lord's inquiry either **in sarcasm** or **defensiveness** (or both). Cain’s **rhetorical** question causes many of us to **assume automatically** that we ***are*** our brother’s keeper. Presumably this happens because we link up the assumed answer to the rhetorical question with the gospel view of mankind in which we are truly brothers and sisters, not, as some say, just stranded mutants on a planet that is a pointless point in space.

First, let us examine the circumstances. Cain was *not* Abel’s keeper, but he was his brother. Brother and keeper relationships are very different. The former emphasizes **concern**, the latter **control**.

Cain slew Abel and even “glorified in that which he had done,” saying, “I am free....” (Moses 5:33.) Cain also coveted Abel’s flocks. Thus, we should distinguish between our need for brotherly love and being our brother's keeper. Cain not only failed to love Abel, he didn’t even care enough about his relationship with Abel to want to improve their relationship.

Abel had found favor with the Lord and Cain had not.This was Cain’s fault, not Abel’s. This brief focus on that sad but illuminating event is necessary before moving not to the assumed issue, but to the real challenge: How, specifically, can we do better in keeping the second great commandment?